

MHacks Winner Benchmarks

San Francisco + Austin | public Devpost galleries | Oct 3, 2024-Oct 3, 2026

The pick

An AI campus auntie matches your free hour to one real Twine event and gives you a personal reason to go - then a QR check-in proves the invite worked.

I would not submit Mama Budget unchanged. Its warm Nigerian-mother character and “necessities stay safe” rule are memorable, but the underlying combination of personal-finance coaching, transaction monitoring, and AI phone calls already appears across several winning entries. The stronger strategic move is to reuse the auntie as the voice of a job Twine is unusually positioned to own: turning a campus event feed into actual attendance.

What the winner pool says about Mama Budget

- The “AI calls you about money” mechanic is no longer enough by itself: Honkler won with AI bill-negotiation calls, DIAL(*) made hotel calls, and finance winners Kasha, Finny, and Min/Max cover budgeting, coaching, and Plaid-driven money decisions.
- Mama Budget still has a distinctive cultural character, a clear stage joke, and a user-protection rule: necessities never trigger shame. Those are strengths, but they need to sit on top of a less crowded core job.
- Twine is a more defensible starting asset than a new bank-connection flow. A demo can use a handful of real or clearly labeled sample campus events, a student's free hour/interests, one personal invitation, and an event QR check-in.
- Voice works best when it serves a specific human need: Be My Voices won an ElevenLabs award for assistive communication, while its team says real-world testing remains ahead. Use stable off-the-shelf speech; keep BOWEN's unverified live quality out of the critical path.

Curated top 10 from the complete index

Selected for relevance to the MHacks tracks and Praise's existing products, not as a universal Devpost ranking. "Winner" includes sponsor awards as well as overall placements; award labels are from the project's displayed Devpost result.

Project / result	Why it matters	Lesson to borrow	Source
Kasha Cal Hacks 12.0 Winner - Visa	Student money management combines spending tracking, shared bills, and timely nudges. This is the closest product-level challenge to Mama Budget.	Keep a concrete student money use case, but the "AI money helper" lane is occupied; Mama Budget needs a defensible behavior or audience edge.	Devpost
Honkler Hack Hack Goose Winner - Best Use of ElevenLabs	AI voice agents call companies to negotiate better bill deals. It directly weakens the novelty claim that a phone call makes Mama Budget new.	A call is a demo channel, not the core innovation. Make the underlying job and outcome distinct.	Devpost
Finny DevHouse SF Edition Winner - SuperMemory	An AI money coach for Gen Z; its persistent, personalized coach framing is close to the "someone who cares enough to react" insight.	Character and continuity can be product logic. Avoid treating a funny voice as the whole moat.	Devpost
Min/Max Hook 'Em Hacks Winner - Intelligent Financial & Market Systems	A Plaid-powered financial copilot surfaces card recommendations inside Apple Wallet, at the moment a decision matters.	Strong timing and delivery matter more than another dashboard. One clear intervention can beat a full budgeting suite.	Devpost
DIAL(*) Cal Hacks 12.0 Winner - three sponsor prizes	The team reports using voice agents to call hotels and booking an SF hotel for \$158. This is an unusually strong live-call demo, although the performance claim is self-reported.	Show one real, legible action and outcome. Do not make the call itself the novelty.	Devpost
Guardian Cal Hacks 12.0 Winner - Bright Data	A fraud-prevention project combines suspicious-charge detection, merchant context, reasoning, and voice alerts.	Finance projects earn trust by protecting the user and explaining why an intervention happened.	Devpost
EcoFin Carbon HackTX 2025 Winner - Best Capital One Hack	Adds a carbon-footprint interpretation to each purchase, joining personal finance and sustainability.	A purchase can support two judging tracks when the second value is measurable and credible.	Devpost
SnackSnap Cal Hacks 11.0 Third place overall	Image recognition verifies recycling; a digital pet gives the user an immediate, visible reward.	The action-to-feedback loop is simple to understand on stage and easy to show working.	Devpost
Storyscale Cal Hacks 11.0 Winner - Google Most Creative App	A choose-your-own-adventure format supports English learning for younger students.	Education ideas stand out when the learner experiences the lesson, not just a content dashboard.	Devpost
LongHorn Guide HackTX 2025 Winner - MLH Best Use of ARM	A campus companion combines navigation and an autonomous robotic tour guide.	Twine gives Praise real campus context. Keep the build narrower than a full navigation robot: one event, one fit, one attendance proof.	Devpost

Demo plan for the recommended pivot

- Main track: Actually Intelligent (AI). Bonus fit: Useless AI and Dumbest Idea; keep the joke warm and useful.
- Input: "I have 45 minutes free, I like live music, and I'm new here." Retrieve only events that exist and fit; let the model write one short auntie-style invite.
- Payoff: invite one opt-in friend or a clearly identified demo persona, then scan the event QR and show attendance change. Do not imply a demo caused real-world attendance beyond the demo.
- Reliability: filter structured events before generation, show the event source, and use off-the-shelf voice. Do not make unverified BOWEN speech quality a dependency.

If you keep Mama Budget

Keep the "needs never get scolded" rule and gele mood display. For a reliable demo, inject three controlled transactions: one need that stays quiet, one discretionary purchase near its user-set limit, and one trigger that produces a reaction. Let deterministic rules decide whether to react; use the model only for the line. Describe Plaid Sandbox as test data, not live monitoring. A Twilio trial call requires a verified destination number.

Complete gallery inventory

The accompanying CSV contains 336 unique winner-badged project entries: 255 from San Francisco galleries and 81 from Austin galleries. It lists every matching project captured from the 20 public Devpost galleries below, with event and project links.

City	Event & Dates	Count	Link
Austin	CSBA x HBA Hack Day Apr 12, 2026	7	Open
Austin	Hack Hack Goose Apr 3-4, 2026	11	Open
Austin	HackTX 2024 Nov 2-3, 2024	14	Open
Austin	HackTX 2025 Oct 18-19, 2025	20	Open
Austin	Hook 'Em Hacks Apr 18-19, 2026	17	Open
Austin	RecordHacks Mar 29-30, 2025	6	Open
Austin	hack.msa Apr 18-19, 2026	6	Open
San Francisco	AGI REAL Agent Challenge Nov 23, 2025	6	Open
San Francisco	Cal Hacks 11.0 Oct 19-20, 2024	62	Open
San Francisco	Cal Hacks 12.0 Oct 24-26, 2025	102	Open
San Francisco	Chinatown Hacks Mar 15-16, 2025	7	Open
San Francisco	Daytona HackSprint SF 2025 Nov 15, 2025	9	Open
San Francisco	DevHouse SF Edition Dec 22-23, 2025	8	Open
San Francisco	Hack for Social Impact 2025 Nov 8-9, 2025	5	Open
San Francisco	Production Agents Hackathon Nov 21, 2025	12	Open
San Francisco	SFHacks 2025 Apr 4-6, 2025	13	Open
San Francisco	SFHacks Code Jams 2024 Oct 1-Nov 1, 2024; overlaps cutoff	3	Open
San Francisco	Self-Evolving Agents Hack Nov 15, 2025	10	Open
San Francisco	SensAI Hack 2025 - San Francisco Dec 5-7, 2025	8	Open
San Francisco	The DEIJ Hackathon Nov 14-15, 2025	10	Open

Coverage and confidence

- “All winners” means all unique projects carrying a Devpost Winner badge in the 20 public galleries searched for these two cities and date window. It includes sponsor-award winners, not only grand-prize winners.
- This is not a census of every hackathon in San Francisco or Austin, and it does not cover all U.S. cities. SFHacks Code Jams spans Oct 1-Nov 1, 2024, so it overlaps the start boundary; its three winner-marked projects are included and the dates are shown in the CSV.
- Awards and product claims come from teams’ Devpost pages. The shortlist assesses concepts and demos; it does not independently verify every claim or predict judges’ decisions.

Build-risk note

Plaid documents transactions as scheduled refreshes with webhooks; for a dependable stage demo, use controlled Sandbox transactions instead of promising every bank purchase arrives immediately. Twilio trial accounts can call only verified destination numbers. These constraints shape the demo claim; they do not rule out the concept.

Technical sources: [Plaid Transactions](#) | [Plaid Sandbox](#) | [Twilio trial restrictions](#)